The Gym Starter Kit

Your first week, a 4-week plan, a log, and a simple grocery list, all in one place

Sweat Cult

> **Important.** This kit is general fitness and nutrition information from an ISSA-certified personal trainer. It is not medical advice and does not replace your doctor. Check with your doctor before starting a new exercise program, especially if you have an injury or medical condition, are pregnant, or have been told to limit exercise. Stop any exercise that causes sharp pain. No specific result is promised or guaranteed.

What's inside

1. **Parts 1–6: First Week at the Gym.** Day 1 to Day 7, machine set-up, etiquette and scripts.
2. **Part 7: The 4-Week Starter Plan.** Three workouts, week-by-week progression, cues and swaps.
3. **Part 8: Your planner and log.** Printable weekly planner, workout log and Sunday check-in.
4. **Part 9: Simple grocery list and meal ideas.** General food information, not a diet.

How to use this kit

You joined a gym (or you're about to) and you don't know what to do when you walk in. That is the most common reason beginners quit in the first few weeks — not laziness, not lack of willpower. It's having no plan.

Part 1 gives you one plan for your first seven days. You will:

- Know what to bring and what to wear.
- Walk the gym once with nothing to prove.
- Do three short, simple full-body workouts on machines and light weights.
- Have scripts for the awkward moments ("Are you using this?").
- Finish the week with a clear next step.

You do not need to do this perfectly. Done is better than perfect. If you miss a day, do that day next. Don't double up.

Time needed: about 20 minutes on Day 1, and about 35–45 minutes on each workout day.

Part 1 — Before you go

What to bring

- Water bottle
- Small towel (optional, but nice)
- Headphones (optional — see the etiquette section)
- Your phone, with the log from this playbook (printed, or a notes app)
- A lock, if the gym uses lockers

What to wear

- Shoes with flat, firm soles. Running shoes are fine for this week.
- Clothes you can move in freely. If you can squat and reach overhead comfortably, you're set.
- Nothing fancy. No one is judging your outfit; most people are focused on their own workout.

When to go

Pick a time when your gym is quieter, if you can. For many gyms that's mid-morning, early afternoon, or late evening, but every gym is different. On Day 1, notice when it's busy and when it isn't — that's useful information.

The mindset that works

For week one, your only goal is **to show up three times and leave feeling like you could have done a little more.** Not exhausted. Not sore for days. You are building a habit first and strength second.

Part 2 — Gym basics in plain English

The layout (most gyms)

1. **Cardio area:** treadmills, bikes, ellipticals, rowers.
2. **Machine area:** weight machines where you sit or lie down and move a handle or pad. These are the best place for beginners because the machine guides the movement.
3. **Free-weight area:** dumbbells, benches, racks, barbells. You'll use light dumbbells this week.
4. **Cable area:** a column of weight plates connected by cables to handles.
5. **Stretching/functional area:** mats, foam rollers, light equipment.

Etiquette that makes you look like a regular

- **Wipe down** any bench or machine after you use it.
- **Re-rack** dumbbells and plates where you found them.
- **Don't hover.** If someone is resting between sets, you can ask: "Are you still using this, or can I work in?"
- **Between sets:** step off the machine if you're checking your phone for more than a minute.
- **Don't film other people** without asking.
- **Headphones:** if you wear them, assume people can't hear you. A small wave or tap on the shoulder gets attention.

Scripts for awkward moments

- *Someone is on the machine you need:* "Hey, how many sets do you have left? I'd like to work in when you're done."
- *You need help setting a weight pin:* "Hi, could you show me how to adjust this?" (Most people are glad to help.)
- *You feel stuck and want to leave:* "I'm going to do one more machine, then I'm done." Finish that one, then leave. Leaving on your own terms counts as a win.
- *Someone gives unsolicited advice:* "Thanks, I'm following a plan from my trainer." (True — it's this one.)

Part 3 — The seven days

Day 1 — Walk-through (about 20 minutes)

You are **not working out hard today.** You're learning the building.

1. Check in. Find the locker room and water fountain.
2. Walk the whole floor once. Say hello to the staff if you want.
3. Find these six machines: **leg press, chest press, seated row, lat pulldown, shoulder press, and the cable station.**
4. Ride a bike or walk on the treadmill for **10 minutes** at an easy pace — you should be able to talk.
5. Try each of the six machines with **the lightest weight, 5 slow reps.** Don't count it as a workout; it's practice.
6. Leave. Write one sentence in your log: "Day 1 done."

Day 2 — Workout A, Machines (35–45 minutes)

Warm-up (5 min): easy bike or walk.

#	Exercise	Sets × reps	Rest
1	Leg press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
2	Machine chest press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
3	Seated cable row	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
4	Machine shoulder press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
5	Plank (on knees or toes)	2 × 15–20 sec	45 sec

How hard? Pick a weight where the last 2 reps feel challenging but your form stays smooth. If you could do 5 more reps, it's too light. If your form falls apart, it's too heavy.

Cool-down (3–5 min): easy walk and gentle stretching of whatever feels tight.

Day 3 — Rest or easy walk

A 15–30 minute walk is plenty. Soreness is normal; sharp or joint pain is not (stop and see a professional if it continues).

Day 4 — Workout B, Dumbbells + cable (35–45 minutes)

Warm-up (5 min): easy bike or walk.

#	Exercise	Sets × reps	Rest
1	Goblet squat (light dumbbell held at chest)	2 × 8–10	60–90 sec
2	Lat pulldown	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
3	Dumbbell Romanian deadlift (light)	2 × 10	60–90 sec
4	Incline push-up on a bench	2 × 6–10	60–90 sec
5	Cable face pull (light)	2 × 12–15	60 sec

Day 5 — Rest

Walk, stretch, drink water, sleep. Rest is part of the plan.

Day 6 — Workout C, Mixed (35–45 minutes)

Warm-up (5 min): easy bike or walk.

#	Exercise	Sets × reps	Rest
1	Leg press	2 × 12	60–90 sec
2	One-arm dumbbell row (hand on bench)	2 × 10 per side	60 sec
3	Machine or dumbbell chest press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
4	Glute bridge	2 × 12	60 sec
5	Farmer carry (light dumbbells, walk 30 sec)	2 rounds	60 sec

Day 7 — Review (10 minutes, no gym needed)

Answer these in your log:

1. Which workout felt best? Which felt worst?
2. What did you do that you thought you couldn’t?

3. What would make next week easier (a different time of day, a gym buddy, a lighter weight)?
4. Which three days next week will you go?

If you finished three workouts, you're no longer a person who "doesn't know what to do at the gym." You've done it.

Part 4 — Machine set-up cheat sheet

For every machine: **start light**, adjust the seat so the handles line up with the middle of your chest (or the pad lines up with the target joint), and move slowly.

Leg press

- Sit back, feet shoulder-width on the plate, toes slightly out.
- Lower the plate until your knees are bent comfortably (don't let your lower back lift off the pad).
- Push through your whole foot. Don't fully lock your knees at the top.

Machine chest press

- Adjust the seat so the handles are about mid-chest height.
- Keep your shoulders down and back against the pad.
- Press out without locking your elbows; lower slowly.

Seated cable row

- Sit tall with a slight bend in your knees.
- Pull the handle toward your belly button, squeezing your shoulder blades.
- Don't lean back far; let your arms stretch forward under control.

Lat pulldown

- Set the thigh pad so your legs are held snugly.
- Grip slightly wider than your shoulders; lean back a little.
- Pull the bar toward your upper chest; return slowly.

Machine shoulder press

- Seat height: handles at about shoulder level.

- Press up without arching your lower back.
- Lower slowly to shoulder level.

Cable station (face pull)

- Set the rope at about upper-chest/face height.
- Use a light weight. Pull the rope toward your face, elbows high.
- Pause for one second; return slowly.

Part 5 — Nerves, doubts, and “what if”

“Everyone is looking at me.” Most people are looking at themselves or their phones. The few who notice you are usually thinking, “good for them for starting.”

“I’m in the way.” Learn the quiet times. If you need a machine, ask. Gyms expect it.

“I’m too out of shape.” Gyms are for people who want to get in better shape. You’re exactly who they’re for.

“I don’t know if I’m doing it right.” Use the cheat sheet, use light weights, and ask staff to check your set-up. A good rule: if the movement is smooth and controlled and you feel the target muscle working, you’re on the right track. If something hurts sharply, stop.

“I skipped a day.” Resume at the next workout. Don’t make up for it by doing two.

“I’m not seeing changes yet.” One week is not enough time to judge your body. The only thing to measure this week is whether you showed up.

Part 6 — Your log and checklist

Print this page or copy it to your notes app.

Week 1 checklist

- [ ] Day 1 — Walk-through done
- [ ] Day 2 — Workout A done
- [ ] Day 3 — Rest/walk
- [ ] Day 4 — Workout B done

- [ ] Day 5 — Rest
- [ ] Day 6 — Workout C done
- [ ] Day 7 — Review done

Workout log

Exercise	Weight used	Sets × reps done	How did it feel? (easy / right / hard)

Rule for next week: when you can do all your reps with smooth form and it feels easy, increase the weight by the smallest amount available.

Part 7 — The 4-Week Starter Plan

You've done your first week. Now you build on it. This plan uses the same three workouts (A, B and C) for four weeks. You're not chasing a new exercise every day. You're getting better at a few simple ones.

Schedule: three non-consecutive days a week (for example Mon / Wed / Fri). If you miss a day, do that workout next and carry on. Don't double up.

How to pick your weight

- Choose a weight where you could do about **2 more reps** after your last rep. That's effort 8 out of 10.
- If all your sets hit the top of the rep range with smooth form for **two workouts in a row**, add the smallest weight increase available next time.
- If form breaks down, drop the weight. Good form beats a heavier weight.
- Pain is not progress. Sharp pain means stop that exercise and use the swap. If it keeps happening, check with a qualified medical professional.

The three workouts

Workout A

Exercise	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Goblet squat	2 × 8–10	3 × 8–10	3 × 8–10	3 × 10–12
Machine chest press	2 × 8–10	3 × 8–10	3 × 8–10	3 × 10–12
Seated cable row	2 × 10	3 × 10	3 × 10	3 × 12
Dumbbell Romanian deadlift	2 × 10	2 × 10	3 × 10	3 × 10
Plank	2 × 20 s	2 × 25 s	2 × 30 s	3 × 30 s

Workout B

Exercise	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Leg press	2 × 10–12	3 × 10–12	3 × 10–12	3 × 12–15
Lat pulldown	2 × 8–12	3 × 8–12	3 × 8–12	3 × 10–12
Dumbbell shoulder press	2 × 10	2 × 10	3 × 10	3 × 10
Glute bridge or hip thrust	2 × 10	3 × 10	3 × 10	3 × 12
Dead bug	2 × 6 per side	2 × 8 per side	2 × 8 per side	3 × 8 per side

Workout C

Exercise	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
Step-up or split squat	2 × 8 per side	3 × 8 per side	3 × 8 per side	3 × 10 per side
Incline push-up or machine press	2 × 8–12	3 × 8–12	3 × 8–12	3 × 10–12
One-arm dumbbell row	2 × 10 per side	3 × 10 per side	3 × 10 per side	3 × 12 per side
Cable face pull	2 × 12–15	2 × 12–15	3 × 12–15	3 × 12–15
Farmer carry	2 × 30 s	3 × 30 s	3 × 30 s	3 × 40 s

Rest 60–90 seconds between sets. Warm up for 5 minutes before every workout.

Cues for the key moves

- **Goblet squat:** hold one dumbbell at your chest, elbows inside your knees, chest tall, heels down.
- **Romanian deadlift:** push your hips back like closing a car door with your hips, soft knees, flat back, dumbbells close to your legs.
- **Row (cable or dumbbell):** pull your elbow toward your ribs; don’t shrug.
- **Lat pulldown:** lean back slightly and pull to your upper chest.
- **Glute bridge:** feet flat, ribs down, squeeze your glutes and pause for one second at the top.
- **Farmer carry:** stand tall, shoulders down, walk with short, steady steps.

Swaps: when something's busy, hurts, or is too hard

If you can't or don't want to do…	Try…
Goblet squat	Box squat to a bench
Leg press	Sit-to-stand from a bench
Chest press	Incline push-up on a bench
Dumbbell shoulder press	Seated machine shoulder press
Lat pulldown	Assisted pull-up machine (lighter)
Seated cable row	Chest-supported row
Romanian deadlift	Hip hinge with a broomstick, then light dumbbells
Step-up	Lower step, or hold a rail
Plank	Incline plank on a bench
Dead bug	Bent-knee heel taps

After week 4

If it felt good, repeat the four weeks and aim to add a little weight or a rep or two. If it felt easy, keep the same plan and add one set to the first exercise of each workout. Staying with the same plan for a few cycles is fine. Boring and consistent beats exciting and quit.

Part 8 — Your weekly planner and log

Print these or copy them into your notes app. Use one planner page per week.

Weekly planner

Week of: _____

Day	Planned workout	Time	Done?
Mon			☐
Tue			☐
Wed			☐
Thu			☐
Fri			☐
Sat			☐
Sun	Plan next week		☐

One thing I'll focus on this week: _____

If I only have 20 minutes: do the first three exercises of today's workout, one set each.

Workout log

Date	Exercise	Weight	Sets × reps	Felt (easy / right / hard)

Weekly check-in (3 minutes, Sunday)

1. How many workouts did I finish? ____ of 3
2. What got in the way when I skipped? _____
3. What's one change that would make next week easier? _____
4. Which days and times will I train next week? _____

Part 9 — Simple grocery list and meal ideas

This is general food information to make planning easier. It isn't a diet, a calorie target or personal nutrition advice. If you have a medical condition, allergies, or are pregnant, check with your doctor or a registered dietitian.

A simple shopping list (one week, flexible)

Proteins (pick 2–3): eggs, chicken breast or thighs, ground turkey, canned tuna, salmon, tofu, Greek yogurt, cottage cheese, beans or lentils.

Carbs (pick 2–3): rice, oats, potatoes or sweet potatoes, whole-grain bread or wraps, pasta, fruit.

Veggies (pick 3–4): spinach or mixed greens, broccoli, bell peppers, carrots, frozen vegetable mix, tomatoes.

Fats and flavor: olive oil, nuts or nut butter, avocado, salsa, soy sauce, spices you like.

Convenience: frozen vegetables, microwave rice, pre-cooked chicken, canned beans. These count.

Easy meal ideas

- **Breakfast:** eggs and toast; oats with fruit and yogurt; Greek yogurt with granola.
- **Lunch:** chicken, rice and vegetables; tuna wrap; burrito bowl with beans.
- **Dinner:** sheet-pan chicken and potatoes; stir-fry with frozen vegetables; pasta with ground turkey and tomato sauce.
- **Snacks:** fruit and nuts; cottage cheese; hummus and carrots; a protein shake if you like.

Make it easier

1. Pick **one** shopping day.
2. Cook one protein and one carb in bulk, mix them with different veggies and sauces.
3. Keep two "no-cook" meals ready for busy days.
4. Don't aim for perfect. Aim for a plan you'll actually follow.

Where to go from here

You now have a first week, a four-week plan, a log and a simple food plan. If you want more structure and someone checking in, the **Gym Starter** founding cohort at **www.sweatcult.shop** includes a weekly plan message and check-ins from an ISSA-certified trainer. It’s a small group, so check the site for open spots.

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